

ANGLO-SAXONS



BY THE END of the 8th century, Britain's people, known as the Anglo-Saxons, had created a rich culture, which included

masterpieces of jewellery, architecture, and literature. Originally these people had come from northern Germany and southern Denmark, where they were known as the Angles, Saxons, and Jutes. In the 3rd and 4th centuries, these tribes travelled to various parts of the Roman Empire, including Gaul, or present-day France, where their influence was short-lived. They travelled to Britain in the 5th century, where they settled, and formed several separate kingdoms. Eventually the kingdom of Wessex became the dominant power.

Culture

Cultural life centred on the monasteries and on the royal court. Alfred the Great gathered scholars and artists around him, and he himself translated many of the Latin classics into Anglo-Saxon, or Old English.



Architecture
Anglo-Saxon churches, like the one at Earls Barton, England, often have square towers decorated with stone relief. This pattern may be based on timber buildings of the period, which have all perished.

Decorated manuscripts

Monks produced quality manuscripts. One monk wrote the work, while a second illustrated it with figures, such as St Dunstan (c.909–988) kneeling before Jesus, and a third decorated it.



Possible image of Alfred the Great



Jewellery
This jewel is inscribed "Alfred ordered me to be made" and may have belonged to Alfred the Great. The inscription and animal-head decoration are finely worked in gold; the portrait, perhaps of the king himself, is made of enamel.

Kingdoms

There was always a struggle for supremacy among the kingdoms formed by the settlers. Northumbria was the earliest one to dominate under Edwin (d. 633). Then it was Mercia's turn under Aethelbald (d. 757) and Offa (d. 796). Finally, Wessex

dominated under Alfred the Great. When Vikings from Denmark attacked and occupied northern England, Alfred stopped them from pushing farther south, and the Anglo-Saxons reconquered the north in the 10th century.



King Canute the Great

By 1016, the Danes ruled all England under the popular Canute (c.995–1035). Canute's sons inherited England, but the Anglo-Saxon Edward the Confessor (c.1003–1066) regained the country in 1042. He had no children and, when he died, an unsettled England was vulnerable to conquest by the Normans.

Edward the Confessor



Canute the Great

Written records

In the 7th century, missionaries from mainland Europe, such as St Augustine of Canterbury, converted the Anglo-Saxons to Christianity. The creation of monasteries meant that more people learned to read and write. Monks produced historical works, such as the *Anglo-Saxon Chronicle*, which today give insights into the events of the period.

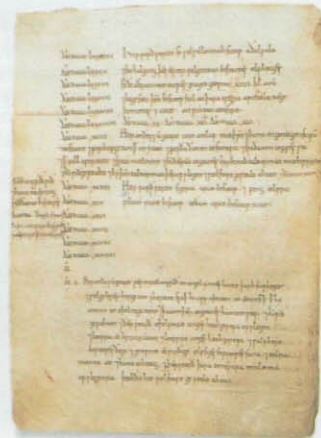
Anglo-Saxon Chronicle

In the ninth century, Alfred the Great ordered the *Chronicle*, a year-by-year account of the history of England. It covers the lives of kings and church leaders, military history, and major events, such as the Viking invasions, and was last updated in 1154.



Bede (c.673–735)

Bede, an English monk and teacher in Jarrow, wrote *A History of the English Church and People*, one of the most important sources of our knowledge of Anglo-Saxon times.



Alfred the Great

Ruler of Wessex and Mercia, Alfred (c.849–c.899) was an able soldier who defended his kingdom against the Vikings. He loved learning and education, and arts and crafts flourished in his reign. He could not drive the Vikings from northern England, but most people saw him as their protector. He was the first English king to become a national symbol.



Timeline

450 Angles, Saxons, and Jutes from northern Germany and Denmark begin to arrive in England. They settle mainly along the eastern coast – East Anglia.



802–39 Reign of Egbert of Wessex. There are many Viking attacks.

871–99 Reign of Alfred the Great, famous for law-making, translating books into Old English, and defeating the Vikings at Edington in 878.



Anglo-Saxon buckle

1016 Canute the Great, a Dane, is elected king by the British; he rules until 1035.

1042 Anglo-Saxons regain power under Edward the Confessor.

1066 Last Anglo-Saxon king, Harold II, is killed by William of Normandy at the Battle of Hastings.

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